1. Current Health Care Delivery System of India – Review

Introduction

- India has a mixed health care system involving both public and private sectors.
- Health care delivery in India is structured to provide accessible, affordable, and equitable services to all citizens.

Levels of Health Care

1. **Primary Health Care**:
    - **Sub-centres (SCs)**: First point of contact between the community and health system. Managed by ANMs and male health workers.
    - **Primary Health Centres (PHCs)**: Act as referral units for 5–6 SCs. Staffed by a medical officer and support staff.
    - Focus: Immunization, antenatal care, health education, basic curative services.
2. **Secondary Health Care**:
    - Provided through **Community Health Centres (CHCs)** and **District Hospitals**.
    - Includes specialist services like surgery, gynecology, pediatrics, and general medicine.
3. **Tertiary Health Care**:
    - Advanced and specialized care provided by teaching hospitals, regional medical institutes, and AIIMS-like institutions.
    - Includes organ transplants, cancer treatment, neuro and cardiac care.

Public Health Infrastructure

- **Rural Health System**: Focused on SCs, PHCs, and CHCs.
- **Urban Health System**: Includes Urban PHCs, Urban Community Health Centres, and Municipal Hospitals.
- Outreach includes ASHA workers, Anganwadi centres, and Mobile Medical Units.

Private Sector

- Plays a significant role in urban and peri-urban areas.
- Offers diagnostic, outpatient, and inpatient services.
- Expensive and often not regulated adequately.

Health Insurance & Government Schemes

- Various schemes such as Ayushman Bharat, Janani Suraksha Yojana, and National Health Mission aim to increase accessibility and affordability.
- Public health insurance is expanding to reduce out-of-pocket expenditure.

Challenges

- Unequal distribution of services (urban vs rural).
- Shortage of trained health workforce.

- High out-of-pocket expenses.
- Infrastructure gaps and poor quality assurance mechanisms.

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2. Planning and Development of Nursing Services and Education

At the Global Level

Planning of Nursing Services

- Nurses are integral to achieving universal health coverage (UHC).
- WHO advocates for expanding the nursing workforce and developing nurse leadership roles.
- Emphasis on advanced practice nurses and midwifery services in primary health care.

Nursing Education Development

- Uniform global standards being developed for nursing curriculum.
- Emphasis on evidence-based practice, critical thinking, and community involvement.
- Increased focus on simulation-based education and digital learning.

At the National Level (India)

Planning of Nursing Services

- Government includes nurses in national health policies and workforce planning.
- Creation of new roles like **Community Health Officers (CHOs)** at Health & Wellness Centres.
- Development of nurse-led clinics and outreach programs.

Development of Nursing Education

- Three primary pathways:
    1. **Auxiliary Nurse Midwife (ANM)**
    2. **General Nursing and Midwifery (GNM)**
    3. **Bachelor of Science in Nursing (B.Sc. Nursing)**
- Postgraduate and specialty nursing programs are being expanded (e.g., M.Sc. Nursing, Nurse Practitioner in Critical Care).
- Indian Nursing Council (INC) revises curriculum regularly to align with global standards.
- Integration of community-based practice, leadership training, and soft skills development.

Key Institutions and Reforms

- National Health Systems Resource Centre and National Institute of Health & Family Welfare provide policy direction.

- National Commission for Allied and Healthcare Professions oversees standardization of education and practice norms.

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3. Recent Trends and Issues in Nursing Service and Management

Recent Trends in Nursing Services

1. **Digitalization of Healthcare**
   - Use of Electronic Health Records (EHRs), telemedicine, and digital platforms.
   - Nurses trained in health informatics and tele-nursing practices.
2. **Nurse-Led Clinics**
   - Nurses managing outpatient services, screening camps, and chronic disease follow-ups independently.
3. **Expanded Scope of Practice**
   - Introduction of Nurse Practitioner roles.
   - Increased autonomy in patient assessment, diagnosis, and management in primary settings.
4. **Community-Based Care**
   - Focus on home-based care, palliative services, and health education at the grassroots level.
5. **Integration of AI and Technology**
   - Use of artificial intelligence for patient monitoring, diagnostics, and decision support in critical care settings.
6. **Increased Emphasis on Mental Health Nursing**
   - Inclusion of psychosocial care and counselling as a core part of nursing services.
7. **Green & Sustainable Healthcare**
   - Nurses leading initiatives to reduce medical waste and implement eco-friendly practices in hospitals.

Issues in Nursing Service and Management

1. **Workforce Shortage**
   - Inadequate nurse-to-patient ratio, especially in rural and public facilities.
2. **Burnout and Workload**
   - Long working hours, inadequate staffing, and high emotional stress leading to burnout.
3. **Limited Career Advancement**
   - Lack of structured promotion paths, poor recognition of advanced qualifications.
4. **Inequitable Distribution**
   - Concentration of skilled nurses in urban and private sectors; shortage in tribal and backward areas.
5. **Gender Disparity**
   - Majority female workforce often facing gender bias and lack of leadership representation.

6. **Training Gaps**
    - Curriculum not always aligned with modern clinical demands.
    - Lack of simulation labs and skill-based practical training in many institutions.
7. **Weak Regulatory Oversight**
    - Unregulated private institutions, variable training quality, and weak implementation of standards.